tectonic and volcanic origin. India's only active volcano is found on Barren Island in Andaman and Nicobar group of Islands.

a) Andaman and Nicobar Islands

These islands are located in an elevated portion of the submarine mountains. Since these islands lie close to the equator, the climate remains hot and wet throughout the year and has dense forests. The area of the island group is about 8,249 sq.km. The entire group of islands is divided into two. They are Andaman in the north and the Nicobar in the south. These island groups are of great strategic importance for the country. Port Blair is the administrative capital of the Andaman and Nicobar islands. The **Ten Degree Channel** separates Andaman from Nicobar group. The southernmost tip, the **Indira Point** is a part of Nicobar Island.

b) Lakshadweep Islands

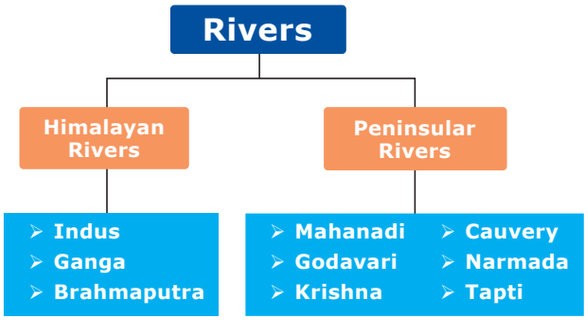
This is a small group of coral islands located off the west coast of India. It covers an area of 32 sq. km. Kavaratti is its administrative capital. Lakshadweep islands are separated from the Maldive Islands by the Eight Degree Channel. The uninhabited "**Pitt Island**" of this group has a bird sanctuary. Earlier, it had three divisions namely Laccadive, Minicoy and Amindivi. It was named as Lakshadweep in 1973.

c) Offshore Islands

Besides the two group of islands, India has a number of islands along the Western Coast, Eastern Coast, in the delta region of Ganga and in the Gulf of Mannar. Many of these islands are uninhabited and are administered by the adjacent states.

1.3 Drainage System of India

A drainage system is an integrated system of tributaries and a trunk stream which collects and drains surface water into the sea, lake or some other body of water. The total area drained by a river and its tributaries is known as a drainage basin. The drainage pattern of an area is the result of the geological structure of the respective areas. The drainage system of India is broadly divided into two major groups on the basis of their location. They are Himalayan rivers and the Peninsular rivers.



Himalayan Rivers

These rivers are found in north India and originate from Himalayas. So, they are also called as Himalayan rivers. These are perennial rivers.

a) The Indus River System

The Indus River is one of the largest rivers of the world. It originates from the northern slope of the Kailash range in Tibet near Manasarovar Lake at an elevation of about 5,150 m. Its length is about 2,880 km (Only 709 km is in India). The river has a total drainage area extending 11,65,500 sq km in which 321,289 sq km areas are drained in India. The river flows through the Ladakh and Zaskar ranges and creates deep gorges. The river runs through Jammu and Kashmir, turns south near Chillar and enters Pakistan. Its major tributaries are Jhelum, Chenab (Largest tributary of Indus), Ravi, Beas and Sutlej. It enters into with the Arabian Sea.

b) The Ganga River System

The Ganga River system is the largest drainage system of India. It extends over an area of 8,61,404 sq km. The Ganga plain is the most densely populated place in India and many towns are developed on the banks of this river. The river Ganga originates as Bhagirathi from the Gangotri Glacier in Uttar Khasi District of Uttarkhand state, at an elevation of 7,010 m.

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